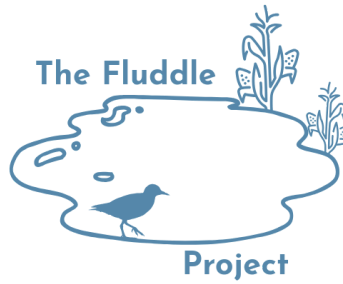


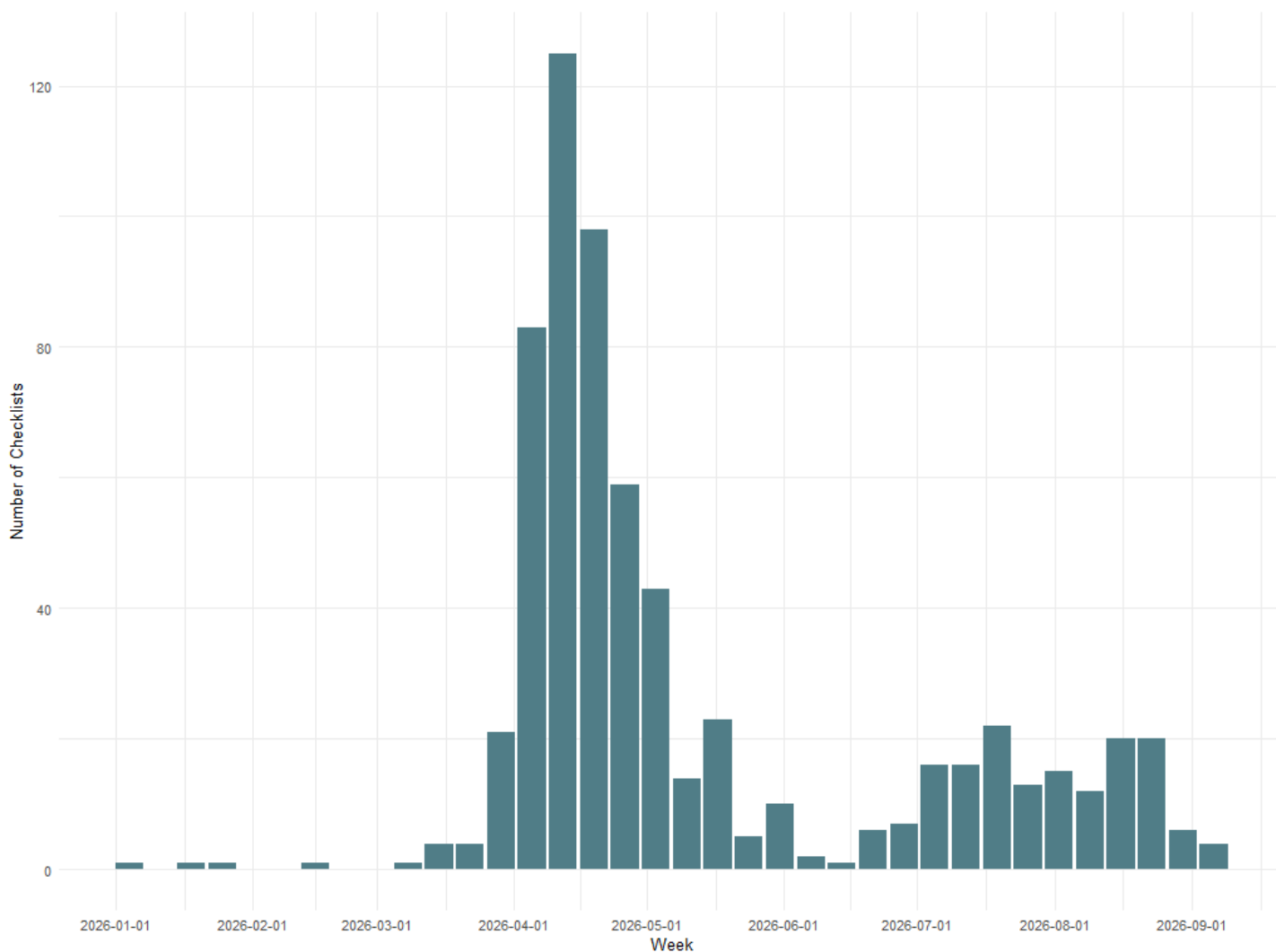
Fluddle Project Updates | September 14, 2026



Fall migration is well underway! I hope everyone has the opportunity to get outside and enjoy the many wonderful migrants – shorebirds or otherwise – passing through Illinois on their way south. The recent warm, dry spell has dried up many of the fluddles we've been monitoring, though I know a few are still out there. That said, I want to wholeheartedly thank everyone who contributed sightings and checklists over the course of this past year.



We started this project in a hurry and we were pleasantly surprised to see how the community responded. As I write this, an incredible **665 complete checklists** have been shared with our project's eBird account. Over **125 checklists** were shared with the account during the week of April 12 alone and at least one checklist has been shared weekly since March 8. When we started looking for volunteers for this project, I couldn't have imagined such incredible enthusiasm and participation. Thank you all!



A bar chart showing the total number of checklists shared each week with the fluddle project account throughout 2026.

Of course, the checklists on their own only tell part of the story. Every checklist you shared also contains a wealth of information about the birds you saw at that fluddle. And this added up throughout the year, with more than **185 species** reported at and around fluddles. This includes **30 species of shorebirds** and **23 species of waterfowl**! Can you guess which of these 30 shorebird species was most frequently observed? Which one had the most individuals observed? Which were least observed? (Answers at the end)

Almost as exciting as the birds themselves are the places we've seen them. Thanks to your efforts, we've documented the locations of over **300 fluddles** across the state and, in an effort to make it easier for birdwatchers to locate potential fluddles near them, I've created a map of every fluddle I found using eBird data. Of course, I am probably missing many, so please let me know using this [form](#) so I can add it to the map (please, submit a separate form for each fluddle). You can browse the map here: <https://univofillinois.maps.arcgis.com/apps/instant/basic/index.html?appid=980a9bbdef534ffa9c7cd8229d51678e>.

With fluddles starting to dry and shorebirds making their way south, I am already busy at work planning for next spring. Keep an eye out for more project and protocol updates later this winter. I hope to have some exciting announcements in the near future. If you are interested in hearing me talk about shorebirds, I will be presenting for the **Kane County Forest Preserve District's [Learn from the Experts](#) series on November 8th.**

Lastly, don't forget that you can continue sharing your eBird checklists with this project either by sharing it the the **FluddlesIL** eBird account or typing **FluddlesIL** in the checklist comments. Additionally, if you have complete checklists made at fluddles in previous years, you are welcome to share those in the same way.

Once again, thank you all for your interest and your support of this project! Please don't hesitate to reach out if you have any questions.

Sincerely,

Alex Smilor (he/him) | Master's Student | University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign

Bird Spotlight Least Sandpiper



Photo credit: Alex Smilor

One of the most frequently observed species and the most common peep at fluddles, the [Least Sandpiper](#) (*Calidris minutilla*) is readily identifiable by its miniscule size, warm brown coloration, and yellow legs. Indeed, its diminutive size wins it the title of the smallest shorebird in the world, weighing less than a pencil and measuring only 5 to 6 inches long! Despite their tiny size, these birds breed in the high arctic and then migrate all the way to the Gulf Coast and South America for the nonbreeding season.

During migration, Least Sandpipers can be found across much of North America, stopping over at many different types of wetlands including fluddles. When visiting a fluddle, watch for them foraging.

[higher on the mudflat](#) than other species. They are often seen foraging further away from the water's edge than other peeps. While feeding, Least Sandpipers move food from the tip of their beak to its mouth using a technique known as [surface tension transport](#). With this method, Least Sandpipers rapidly open and close their beak to move food trapped in tiny water droplets upwards, defying gravity! This same behavior has been observed in a number of other species, most notably in phalaropes. This [video](#) by Jeff Ellerbusch on the Macaulay Library captures this behavior at the 16 second mark.

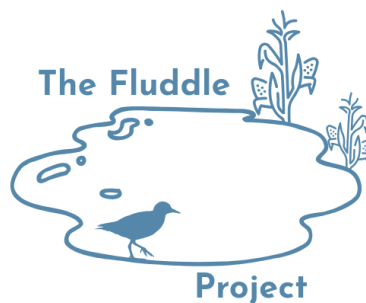
While birdwatching, be sure to pay special attention to Least Sandpipers and other small sandpipers. They can be challenging to identify but accurate identification is valuable to track population trends. If you ever have doubts about an identification, snap a photo or write a description and send me an email. I'm happy to help.

Answers:

Most frequently observed: Killdeer (558)

Most individuals observed: Pectoral Sandpiper (21,488)

Least observed: Western Sandpiper (1 observation), Marbled Godwit (3), Sanderling (3), Upland Sandpiper (3), Buff-breasted Sandpiper (4)



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